



Smartphones

The year 2012 was an absolute blur, particularly for someone who covers smartphones as a beat. No sooner had one phone got launched than you had the 'leaks' and 'rumours' about the next big launch. The market was more aggressive than ever and if this trend continues next year as well, then expect a virtual bloodshed in this segment.

The highlights of the year inevitably included the new iPhone, which sported a bigger display and more power. The Apple Maps' futility, helplessness and incompetence did spoil the fun though.

Samsung led Android's charge with the Galaxy SIII and made the phablet category even more enticing with the very powerful Galaxy Note II. Equally enlightening was the courtroom saga with Apple, something that still continues. Google launched its flagship Nexus 4 in collaboration with LG at a sweet price of USD 300 in the US, but expect Indian pricing to be much higher. It launched with the stock Android 4.2 OS, also named Jelly Bean.

Quad-core processors became commonplace with the HTC One X, HTC One X+ and LG Optimus 4X HD, which are possible alternatives for someone who wanted a very powerful phone. The dual-core processors are now the way forward for mid-range Android phones and Sony is leading that with the NXT range of phones and the Xperia U and Xperia Sola are prime examples. Even so, the more affordable phones now clearly are better built, and have impressive specs – something that was inconspicuous by its absence till now.

Microsoft started off the year with the Tango 7.5 update for Windows Phone. Along the way came some really competent smartphones, with the Lumia 800 and the Lumia 900 being prime examples. The Redmond giant ended the year with a bang – Windows Phone 8. Expect some massive activity around the Windows Phone ecosystem next year.

Symbian possibly took its last mighty swing with the Nokia 808 PureView. The phone was disappointing because the OS is dated, but the camera was rather brilliant. For someone who wants a phone that works and will utilise the camera more, this is a very good option. And with the budget Windows phones now arriving in the sub ₹10,000 price bracket, the consumers now have a wider choice available.

Blackberry has been fairly silent in 2012, with no exciting phones launched. Yes, there was an entry-level Curve for the college crowd, but that's about it.

So let's get down to the awards, shall we.



◀ **HIGH-END:**
SAMSUNG GALAXY SIII
Price: ₹37,900

High-end

Zero1 Winner
Samsung Galaxy SIII

This is by far the best Android phone to hit the market this year. Yes, there were the pretenders to the throne – the HTC One X and the LG Optimus 4X HD, but the Galaxy SIII was by far the best phone among all. The performance scores blow the rivals out of the water. We heard a lot of criticism directed at Samsung for sending out the Galaxy SIII with the pentile display, but we had said it back then, and will say it again now – this is a non-issue, and will not stop millions from buying it. Back to the present, and those words of wisdom have come true!

Apart from the excellent performance, the Galaxy SIII also has some very nifty little features. Smart Stay keeps the display switched on as long as you are looking at it. Pop-up play lets you play a video and pin it anywhere on the screen while you continue working on another application. Direct dial lets you call a contact by just opening their contact in the address book and bringing the phone close to your ear. As if all this wasn't enough, the TouchWiz UI is very well optimized and doesn't hamper performance like a lot of Android skins that come with various phones. All in all, this is the phone to buy if you want the top-of-the-line Android phone in the market today.



Apple iPhone 5
Price: ₹45,500



Samsung Galaxy Note II
Price: ₹37,990

Worthy Mentions
Apple iPhone 5

The advert says, "Best thing to happen to the iPhone, since the iPhone". We have to agree. As if the iPhone 4S wasn't brilliant enough, the iPhone 5 just takes that extra step in terms of build quality. The bigger footprint comes from the vertical height and that is because of the bigger display. The OS remains